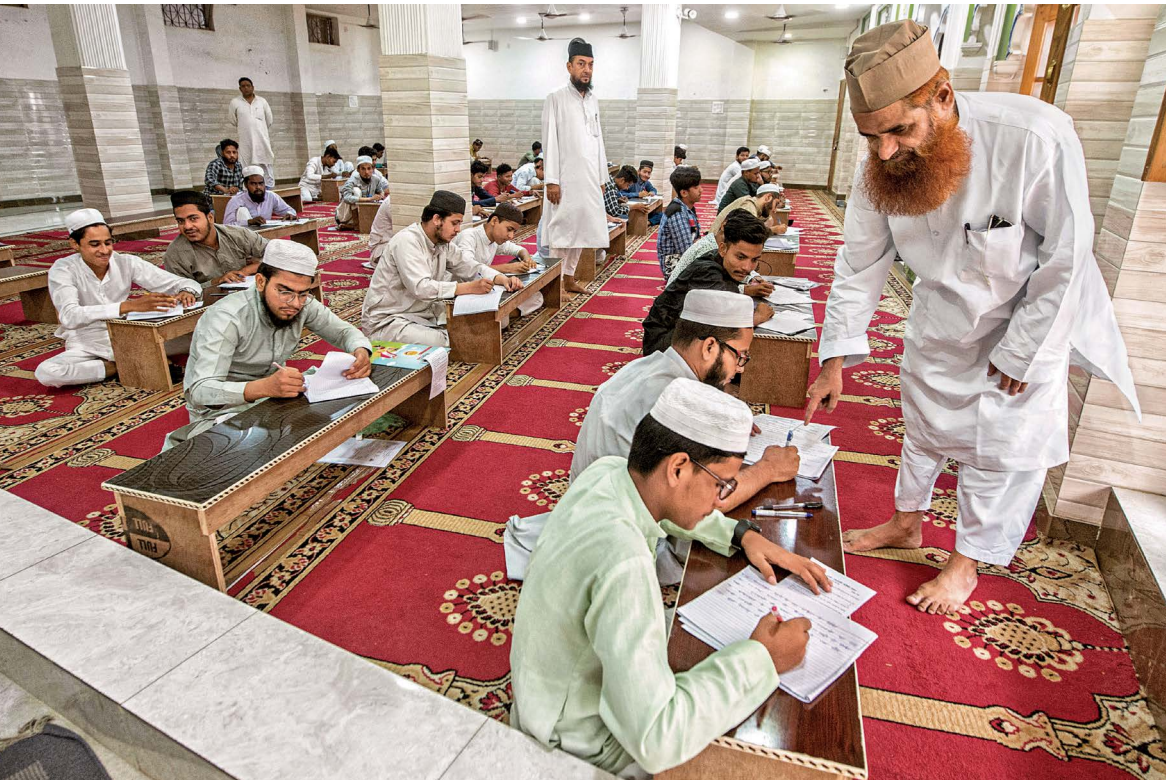
MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



MEDIUM OF INSTRUCTION A total of 1,622 madrasas are registered with the MP Madrasa Board. They are all under scrutiny now

MADHYA PRADESH

ALL EYES ON SEMINARIES

been served for their derecognition.

An estimated 5,000 non-Muslim students are enrolled as students in the 1,622 madrasas registered with the MP Madrasa Board, whose total enrolment reaches around 100,000. Madrasas offer education from standards 1-8, after which students have to enrol in regular schools. There are broadly three kinds of madrasas. The government-aided ones impart not just religious instruction, or Deen-i-Taleem, but also teach modern subjects like Maths, Science, Social and Environmental Sciences. Unrecognised madrasas may or may not offer modern education. The third category consists of those that only offer religious learning.

If religious instruction is an important part of the curriculum, why would non-Muslim children take admission in madrasas? The answer apparently lies in the system of grants to madrasas that led to their sudden proliferation across the state around 20 years ago.

BJP leader Murli Manohar Joshi,

ACTION AGAINST MADRASAS BEGAN AFTER A QUERY TO THE MP GOVT, ASKING IF HINDU CHILDREN HAVE BEEN ENROLLED AGAINST PARENTS' WISHES

Union HRD minister from 1998-2004, had laid the basis for the Scheme for Providing Quality Education in Madrasas, which was launched in the late 2000s. Under it, each madrasa that opted to introduce modern educational subjects in their curriculum got an annual grant which covered salaries of three teachers. Besides this, students at such madrasas got uniforms and books. The state government topped this with an annual maintenance grant of Rs 50,000.

"The Narendra Modi government discontinued its financing for the madrasa modernisation project in December 2016, under which each registered madrasa was getting a monthly salary of Rs 6,000 for three teachers," says Mohammed Suhaib Qureshi, president, Adhunik Madrasa Kalyan Sangh (Modern Madrasa Welfare Association). The state government still provides maintenance expenditure and mid-day meals. Sources in the school education department say that the number of madrasas increased after the grants started in the early 2000s. Some madrasas with non-Mus-